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Letter to C.D. Walcott, Esq. Secretary Smithsonian Institution February 8, 1907

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February 8, 1907.
C. D. Walcott, Esq.
Secretary Smithsonian Institution.
Dear Sir:

Agreeably to your request I have looked over the paper by A. McAdie entitled "Earthquakes on the Pacific Coast, Chronological record from 1897 to 1906" submitted to the Smithsonian Institution, and beg to submit for your consideration the following comments thereon:

The first 114 pages is a record of observed earthquakes up to January 1st, 1906, of the same general character as similar records prepared by Holden and Perrin, and published as bulletins of the U. S. G. S., and would in my judgment be suitable for publication in the same way. The first four photographs, illustrating the destructive effects of the earthquake of 1898 at the Navy Yard, Mare Island, would not be amiss although the seismological significance of the effects there are nowhere discussed in the record.

The greater part of the report from pp. 115 to 172 deals with certain phases of the earthquake of the 18th of April and the after shocks of the same. If this were a complete record of time and localities of the shocks of the year 1906 there would, I think, be no objection to it, although it would to some extent traverse the ground gone over more thoroughly by the State Earthquake Investigation

Commission. But as a record of shocks, it is very incomplete. In the list of after shocks of the California Earthquake now before me in the data of the Commission, we have many more shocks than McAdie appears to have any knowledge of. And even these are not always, as they profess to be, in chronological order. For example on page 126, an earthquake which occurred in Southern California and which was recorded at San Diego at 4:29:45 p. m. is listed before others that occurred at 5:48 a. m. and 5:13 a. m.

Thispart of the report is not, however, what it purports to be - a chronological record. It is made up to the extent probably of 25 per cent of its contents of reprints of former publications and contributed notes of a very miscellaneous kind. There are five printed pages that have appeared in the publications of the Weather Bureau. One printed page dealing with phenomena at Manila which is somewhat foreign to the record in its proposed scope. There is a paper by Omori, which has been published before in English and is the scientific libraries. There is a paper by Marvin in quotation marks on the record made by the Weather Bureau Seismograph at Washington, D. C., and one by Baur and Barbank on magnectic observations. If these articles form a proper feature of a chronological record then the paper is very partial, not to say defective, since so meagre an excerpt from the more important seismological stations of the world does not do the subject justice. The

report of the Earthquake Commission now in preparation will cover this ground much more satisfactorily.

The earthquake of April 18, 1906, was so important an event from the purely scientific point of view that I should deprecate the publication of any such partial and incomplete account of the records, especially when a much more complete account of the phenomena and a discussion of their significance is under way and nearing publication.

As regards the illustrations, seven photos illustrate destructive effects of the earthquake in San Francisco, which are not in any way discussed in the text. Two are maps of the region which have already been published by Ransome in his paper in the National Geographic Magazine and there is nothing in the text that calls for the reproduction of those maps. One photo shows the Stanford Memorial Church before the earthquake, but not after, and another shows the wrecked Memorial Arch, at Stanford University, although the effects at Stanford are not discussed in the text. The seismogram obtained at the U. S. Weather Bureau, at Washington, D. C., is given twice, once on the original scale and once in reduced form, as already elsewhere published.

The seismograms of Tokyo and Manila have already been published, as has also the magnetographs of the U. S. C. and G.

Survey at Cheltenham. There are three photographs of the seismograph at the Weather Bureau at Washington and a seismogram from the Lick Observatory. These illustrations are not without interest in connection with suitable text, but neither the seismograms nor the relative merits of seismographs are in any way discussed in the text.

On the whole, the "chronological record" gives the distinct impression of inappropriate padding and is not prepared with the scientific coherence that should characterize the publications of the Smithsonian Institution.

In closing I may say that it is not a matter of any concern to the Commission whether the paper appears in its present form or not, but seems to me personally a pity that so fragmentary an account of the California earthquake should be published when a more complete discussion will be shortly forth coming.

Probably the best solution of the question would be to publish the first 114 pages as a bulletin of the Survey, thus placing on record the list of eathquakes so far as McAdie knows them up to January 1st, 1906.

Yours sincerely